

From Blue Flag to Red Alert?

Fajtata Bay, the 2025 closures and what the EU bathing-water data show

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“The same government that boasts about the ‘quality’ of our beaches ends up having to close them within days.”

Nationalist Party (PN), statement of 1 July 2025, as reported by MaltaToday.
After Fajtata Bay was closed two days after 13 Blue Flags were announced.

VERDICT: LARGELY SUPPORTED

Sequence accurate; ‘systemic failure’ is an opinion

Version 1.0 · 5 October 2026

Status: no right of reply needed

Prepared from public sources and EEA data.

Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT

Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

On 1 July 2025 the Nationalist Party (PN) said that “the same government that boasts about the ‘quality’ of our beaches ends up having to close them within days”, after Fajtata Bay in Marsaskala was closed to bathers two days after the government announced 13 Blue Flag beaches. We checked the dates, the causes of the closures and what the EU bathing-water data say.

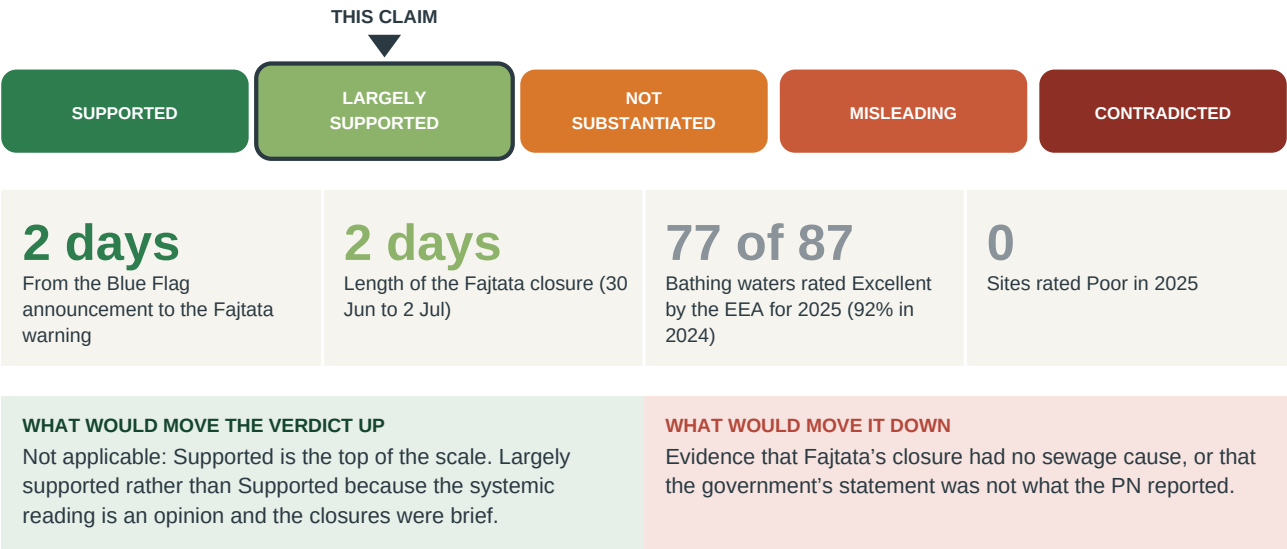
- 1

The sequence is as the PN described it. The 13 Blue Flags, Fajtata Bay among them, were announced on Saturday 28 June 2025. The Environmental Health Directorate (EHD) advised against bathing at Fajtata on Monday 30 June because foul water overflowed near the public toilets, and lifted the warning on 2 July after repeated sampling.
- 2

Closures for sewage did happen that season, but they were short and local. Qui-si-Sana (Sliema) was closed 18–24 June after a private establishment’s drain failed. Fajtata was closed for about two days. Xlendi, which the PN also listed, was closed for run-off after rain, which the Water Services Corporation said was not sewage.
- 3

The national picture is much better than ‘Red Alert’ suggests. In the EEA’s 2025 classification, 77 of Malta’s 87 bathing waters are Excellent (88.5%), none is Poor, and Fajtata has been Excellent every season since 2015. The share of Excellent sites has fallen from 92% in 2024.
- 4

Verdict: largely supported (moderate confidence). The facts the PN cited are accurate. Its wider inference, a failure of infrastructure over years, is an opinion that a single toilet overflow cannot test, and we do not rate it.



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1 The claim and what we could verify

The PN issued the statement on 1 July 2025; it is reported in full by the Malta Independent [1] and by MaltaToday [2]. We could not find it on the party’s own site, and the quotations below are the outlets’ English rendering of a statement that may have been issued in Maltese. The sentence recorded for this check, “the government celebrates Blue Flag beaches while bathing sites close for sewage contamination”, is the headline sense of that statement.

Source	What it says	Our access	Status
PN statement, 1 Jul 2025, in MaltaToday [2]	“The same government that boasts about the ‘quality’ of our beaches ends up having to close them within days.” Also: “This is yet another structural failure that reveals how the Government has done nothing for years to protect and maintain the country’s infrastructure.”	Read in full (Internet Archive copy).	The claim
EHD notice, 30 Jun 2025, in MaltaToday, Newsbook, TVMnews [3]	“Bathing is not recommended due to an overflow of foul water in the vicinity of the public toilets.”	Read via the outlets; EHD site refuses automated access.	Primary notice, second-hand
Government announcement, 28 Jun 2025 [4]	Ten beaches in Malta and three in Gozo, Fajtata Bay among them, awarded the Blue Flag; announced by the Minister for Foreign Affairs and Tourism.	Lovin Malta read; press release itself not retrievable ♦.	Context
EEA bathing-water data [5]	Class of each of Malta’s 87 sites, 2015–2025.	Downloaded 5 Oct 2026 (data/cc-005).	Primary data

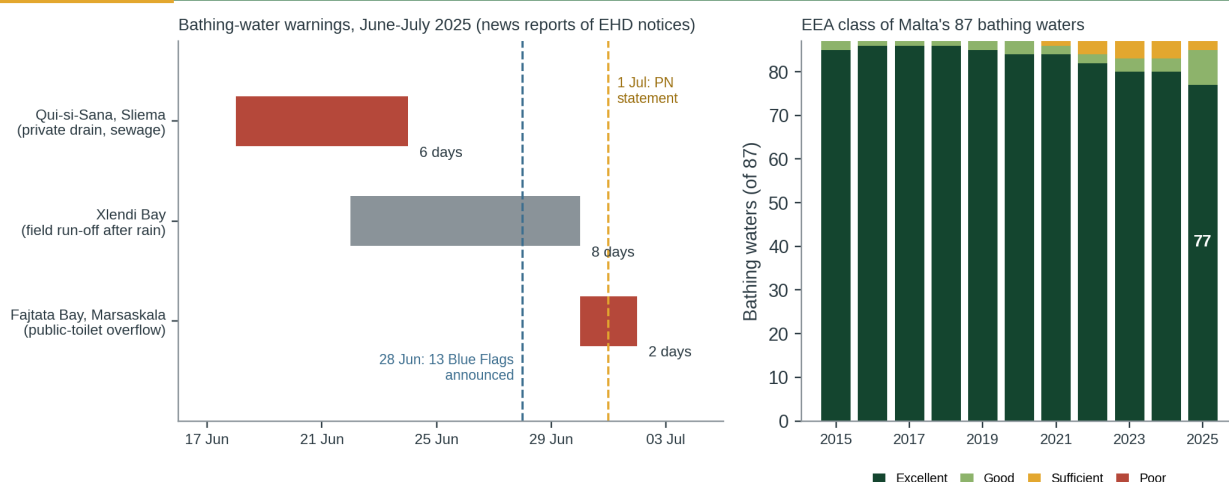
2 Method

Question. Did the events the PN described happen as it said, and do they bear out the impression that Malta’s bathing sites are being closed for sewage?

Evidence. We split the statement into sub-claims (Section 5), dated each event from news reports of the EHD’s notices (*data/cc-042/events_2025.csv*), and took the EU-standard classification of every Maltese bathing water from the European Environment Agency (EEA), reusing the data gathered for Claim Check 005 (*tools/cc-042-report/calc.py*). The EHD’s own closure reports could not be downloaded, so every closure cause is second-hand (♦).

Grades. EEA data are grade C (official statistics); the notices are official but reached us through news reports (C, second-hand). The PN’s inference about infrastructure is an assertion (D). **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

3 What the record shows



Sources: Environmental Health Directorate notices as reported by MaltaToday, Malta Independent, Lovin Malta (dates: see data/cc-042/events_2025.csv); EEA bathing-water data, retrieved 5 Oct 2026.

Figure 1. Left: three warnings around the Blue Flag announcement, with dates from news reports of EHD notices. Right: EEA class of Malta's 87 bathing waters by season (the number is 2025's Excellent sites).

Timeline. The Blue Flags were announced on Saturday 28 June; MaltaToday's report of the Fajtata notice is timed 12:45 on Monday 30 June, about two days later; the warning was lifted on 2 July after "repeated sampling of seawater", so it lasted about two days. A summary of the EHD's official record that we saw gives 28 June to 2 July for the same event ♦; if so, the closure began on the day the flags were announced, which would make the PN's '48 hours' slightly generous to the government, not to the PN.

Causes. At Fajtata the EHD named an overflow of foul water near the public toilets; the Labour Party called it "a problem with a public convenience" [1], and the EHD later said the irregularity in the "sewage system of the public lavatory" had been rectified [6]. That is sewage contamination of a bathing site, from a local fault. At Qui-si-Sana, the EHD traced the leak to a private establishment's drainage ♦. At Xlendi the closure followed rain: the EHD report speaks of run-off from fields and the Water Services Corporation said no sewage was involved ♦; the PN's list of 'sewage spills' (as MaltaToday paraphrases it) includes Xlendi, which overstates it.

The wider data. In the EEA's classification, which rests on four seasons of samples, 77 of the 87 sites are Excellent for 2025, 8 Good, 2 Sufficient and none Poor. This is lower than 2024 (80 Excellent, 92%), and the share of Excellent sites has slipped from 98.9% in 2018, but it is far from a 'red alert'. Fajtata (site A07, Triq il-Qaliet) has been Excellent in every season from 2015 to 2025. The EEA dataset also counts samples taken during short-term pollution events: 3 in 2022, 9 in 2023 and 11 in 2024 (the 2025 count was not yet published). The Labour Party's reply cited the EU report's "over 92%" Excellent figure [1]; that is the 2024 figure, not 2025's 88.5%.

4

Where the evidence points different ways

Do the closures show a failing system, or isolated faults?

OPEN

FOR THE PN'S INFERENCE

Several warnings in the weeks before the statement (Qui-si-Sana, Fond Ghadir, St Thomas Bay, Fajtata) involve drainage or stormwater. Malta was found, as the PN notes, to have breached EU environmental law on sewage discharges, and the share of Excellent sites has drifted down since 2018.

AGAINST

Each cause reported by the EHD is local: a public toilet, a private establishment's drain, field run-off. The warnings were lifted within days after sampling, no site is rated Poor, and Fajtata itself is Excellent in every season. The Labour Party says the PN made a national issue of a public-convenience fault [1].

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

Both are partly right. The sequence the PN reported is accurate and closures for sewage did occur; whether they reveal a structural failure over years needs an analysis of all closures and their causes, which the EHD's reports could support but which we could not read.

5

Testing the claim

Sub-claim	Said by	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. The government celebrated 13 Blue Flag beaches, Fajtata among them, on 28 June 2025	PN [1]	The Minister for Tourism announced ten Maltese and three Gozitan Blue Flags at Golden Bay, Fajtata Bay included [4] ♦. The Blue Flag itself is awarded by Nature Trust–FEE Malta.	SUPPORTED
B. Fajtata was closed to bathers within days ('48 hours') of the announcement	PN [1]	EHD notice 30 June; lifted 2 July [3][6]. Possibly 28 June per a summary of the EHD record ♦.	SUPPORTED
C. Bathing sites close because of sewage contamination in 2025	PN [1]	True for Fajtata and Qui-si-Sana. Xlendi was run-off, not sewage ♦. Closures were short; 77 of 87 sites are Excellent for 2025 and none is Poor.	LARGELY SUPPORTED
D. This reflects years of government neglect of infrastructure	PN [1]	An opinion about causes and responsibility; a single public-toilet overflow cannot test it.	NOT RATED

6

Verdict

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

The facts cited are accurate; the inference of systemic failure is an opinion the data neither confirm nor refute. Confidence: moderate.

Why. Our scale rates a claim *Largely supported* when the evidence backs the substance with only minor caveats. The Blue Flag announcement, the Fajtata closure for foul water and its timing, and the occurrence of sewage-related closures that season are all documented. The caveats are that Xlendi was not sewage, that the closures were brief, and that Malta's bathing waters remain overwhelmingly rated Excellent. Confidence is moderate because the causes come from news reports of the EHD's notices, not the EHD's own reports.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say that Malta's sewage infrastructure is adequate, or that it is not; Section 4 sets out why that needs a separate analysis. A fairer summary of the evidence: *"Two days after the Blue*

Flag announcement, Fajtata Bay was closed for about two days because of a public-toilet overflow; other sewage closures occurred that June, but Malta’s bathing waters remain mostly Excellent.” The PN and the Labour Party were each right about part of this.

RIGHT OF REPLY

Not needed: the verdict is Largely supported.

7 Limitations

- The EHD’s closure reports and notices refuse automated access and are not archived; causes and dates are from news reports (second-hand, ♦). A maintainer can add the PDFs.
- We did not read the PN’s statement in Maltese or on its own site; the quotations are the outlets’ English text.
- The Blue Flag press release was not retrievable; the list of beaches is from Lovin Malta and a search summary ♦.
- We did not count every 2025 closure; the PN’s own list of nine EHD closure reports is a lead, not evidence.
- The EEA 2025 class is the in-season update; the EEA’s final 2025 report may differ slightly.

References

- [1] The Malta Independent (1 Jul 2025). Marsascala beach goes from Blue Flag to Red Alert in 48 hours, PN says; PL responds. <https://www.independent.com.mt/articles/2025-07-01/local-news/Marsascala-beach-goes-from-Blue-Flag-to-Red-Alert-in-48-hours-PN-says-6736271331>
- [2] MaltaToday (1 Jul 2025). ‘From Blue Flag to Red Alert’: PN slams government over beach closures. https://www.maltatoday.com.mt/news/national/135722/from_blue_flag_to_red_alert_pn_slams_government_over_beach_closures
- [3] MaltaToday (30 Jun 2025). Fajtata Bay closed to bathers after public toilet overflow spills into sea; Newsbook; TVMnews (EHD notice). https://www.maltatoday.com.mt/news/national/135697/fajtata_bay_closed_to_bathers_after_public_toilet_overflow_spills_into_sea_
- [4] Lovin Malta (Jun 2025). Fajtata Beach Closed Due To Sewage Leak Days After Earning Blue Flag Status; Office of the Deputy Prime Minister press release, 28 Jun 2025 ♦. <https://lovinmalta.com/lifestyle/announcements/fajtata-beach-closed-due-to-sewage-leak-days-after-earning-blue-flag-status/>
- [5] European Environment Agency. Bathing Water Directive data (DiscoMap, DiscoData), retrieved 5 Oct 2026. <https://www.eea.europa.eu/en/topics/in-depth/bathing-water>
- [6] MaltaToday (Jul 2025). Fajtata Bay open to swimmers again. https://www.maltatoday.com.mt/news/national/135753/fajtata_bay_open_to_swimmers_again
- [7] Miżien. Data and script: data/cc-042/; tools/cc-042-report/calc.py.

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	5 Oct 2026	First issue. Verdict Largely supported (moderate confidence); no right of reply needed.